

About the Author

Hani M.M. Al-Shater has died twice.

The first time, he was a kid, and someone explained that "superhero" is not a job. He took it badly, then took up computers, which is what you do when you can't fly.

The second time, he was deep in a respectable career, watching the promotion cycle come round again, when he noticed he was enjoying it. Not the work. The wheel.

The afterlife was awkward. He was too much of a builder to be a philosopher and too much of a philosopher to be a proper engineer, not quite from where he was born and not quite from where he lives. Friends kindly pointed out that he had a good job and a family, so what exactly was the problem. He agreed. That was the problem.

He kept building anyway, and every time a crack appeared, a very reasonable voice explained why it didn't matter. You cannot argue with that voice; reasoning is the voice. So he took up what he calls epistemic sarcasm: a joke that burns everything to the ground so you can build something new from the rubble.

Since then he wakes at midnight, makes a coffee that is too hot, burns his assumptions and talks to an AI in incognito mode, the one place he can be whole with no strings attached. A life emerges in the chat window, then vanishes, as weirdly as ours do. It is an odd habit for a man who wrote a book about keeping records.

Eventually he found out he wasn't in between after all. He belonged to a rare old species, the philosopher-builder, which AI is about to make a lot less rare.

In daylight he keeps a vow: to drag philosophy out of the seminar room and onto the street, where people are trying to work out what AI means for their lives. This book is part of keeping it.

Somewhere there is a timeline where he became a superhero. He switched that one to cartoons.

Outside of that, he lives in Berlin with his beloved wife and four kids, and serves as Head of Applied Science at Zalando.